

179

People aboard

Attributed to a review of boarding-area CCTV. The manifest recorded 133.

73

Bodies recovered

Official figure, unchanged from 24 to 26 July. 69 identified.

~103

Implied by subtraction: 179 aboard less 76 survivors

No official death toll appears in the corpus.

87

Years since the hull was built

1939, Ferguson Brothers, Port Glasgow, via the Crown Agents, per the Paxman engine register.

0

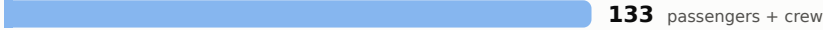
Survey, load-line or capacity certificates in the corpus

Searched for across 152 sources and not found.

1. The manifest and the complement

Of the 116 passengers on the manifest, Minister Edghill stated 100 booked through the Online Booking System and 16 through Mobile Money Guyana. The Associated Press reports that clerks had sold unmanifested seats for cash “for decades at state-run ferry terminals.”

Recorded on the manifest



Established by the CCTV review



difference of 46

The first 67 survivors, checked against the manifest

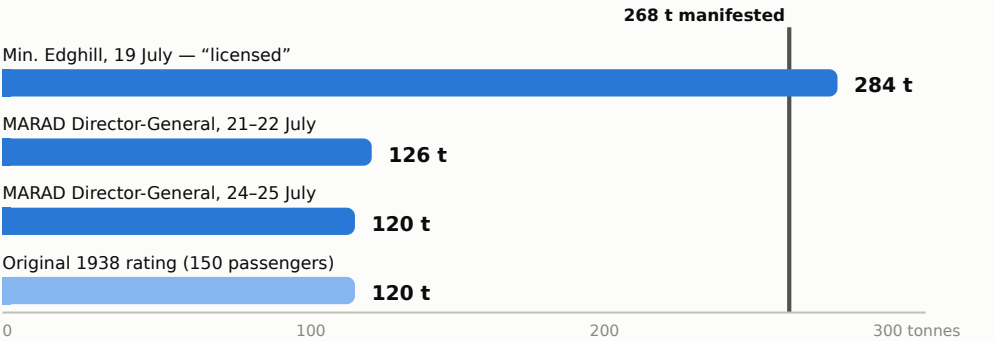


On the manifestNot recorded as having boarded

Edghill stated on 19 July that 35 of the 67 then rescued appeared on the manifest, and that authorities could no longer determine how many had been aboard. DPI releases of 19 July state that families were being updated using the vessel’s manifest.

2. Stated capacity limits

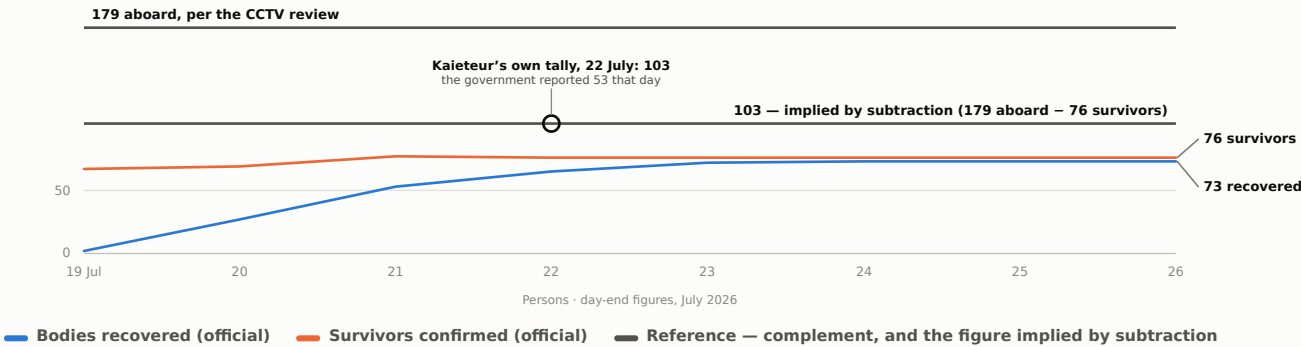
Officials gave different limits on different days. Asked when the 1938 rating was raised, MARAD’s Director-General said: “I don’t have that information.”



Three of the four stated limits sit below the 268 tonnes the vessel was manifested to carry; the fourth, Edghill’s 284 tonnes, sits above it. Edghill’s own line-by-line audit on 19 July returned 260 tonnes. On 22 July MARAD stated the vessel was “not overloaded,” citing the load line. No published certificate appears in the corpus against which any of these figures can be checked.

3. Recovery and survivor figures

Bodies recovered reached 73 on 24 July and were unchanged through 26 July. Survivors were revised from 77 to 76 after de-duplication, per News Room and Kaieteur. Kaieteur published its own tally of 103 on 22 July, compiled from Coast Guard, opposition, private-vessel and fishermen’s accounts, on a day the government reported 53.



EVERY PLOTTED VALUE

July	Recovered	Survivors	Not accounted for
19	2	67	—
20	27	69	83 “missing”
21	53	77	—
22	65	76	103 (implied)
23	72	76	103 (implied)
24	73	76	30 “unaccounted”
25	73	76	103 (implied)
26	73	76	103 (implied)

Government releases report bodies recovered; no official death toll appears in the corpus. On 24 July the Prime Minister gave “30 unaccounted for,” against 83 “missing” four days earlier. Neither figure is reconciled in any source.

4. The voyage, hour by hour

15:15

Departs the T&HD wharf at Kingston, Georgetown, for Port Kaituma. 116 passengers and 17 crew on the manifest.

~19:00

Survivor Leon Murray (AP) states one engine failed about four hours out and the crew repaired it at sea rather than turning back.

~20:00

Murray states a passenger reported water on the lower deck and was told: “They told us this is normal.”

23:01

A Mayday is widely reported at this time. On 25 July the Prime Minister said of a Mayday from the captain: “We have no such record.”

01:36

Capt. Gouveia takes off from Ogle in a private fixed-wing Islander, 2h 35m after the reported Mayday, and reports coordinates from a sighted flare. Two military helicopters were reported unserviceable.

03:15

Edghill announces eight retrieved alive. Guyana Times reports fisherman Hareesh Singh located the hull.

Survivor accounts describe a packed lower deck (Murray), cargo stacked at the stern (Elena Moonsammy) and a list that did not right itself (Wayne Kitson). MARAD’s Director-General stated that a vessel with positive stability returns upright even when heeled twenty degrees, and attributed the failure to right to operational error in treacherous conditions. The two accounts are not reconciled in any source. Reported sinking duration ranges from about four minutes (Murray) to “less than a minute” (Guyana Times).

5. Vessel and institutional record, 1939–2026

Concern raised on the recordExpenditure or allocationLives lostOrigin



6. Conditions recorded, and proposals on the record

RECORDED IN THE SOURCES

- 1

One vessel on the route.

After the sister ship’s reported 2019 withdrawal the Barima was the only vessel on the Georgetown–Port Kaituma run.
- 2

The replacement never ran the route.

The Ma Lisha, commissioned 2023, did not serve Port Kaituma — incomplete wharf works per PM Phillips, insufficient cargo capacity per residents.
- 3

Three stated capacity figures, no published certificate.

MARAD said it could not date the increase from the 1938 rating of 120 t and 150 passengers.
- 4

Thirty-two survivors were not on the manifest.

AP reports clerks had sold unmanifested seats for cash “for decades at state-run ferry terminals.”
- 5

Four hours between the reported engine failure and the Mayday.

No Pan Pan urgency call is established in the corpus.
- 6

The regulator reports to the operator’s ministry.

MARAD stated the vessel was not overloaded on 22 July, before any inquiry existed.

PROPOSALS MADE BY IDENTIFIED PARTIES

- 1

Amerindian Peoples Association:

a review of Guyana’s entire river and sea transport system, with mandatory consultation of Indigenous and riverain communities.
- 2

APNU:

the National Assembly, not the President, should set the inquiry’s terms of reference. David Patterson alleges procurement advice was disregarded (uncorroborated).
- 3

Joint five opposition parties:

a marine casualty investigation under SOLAS and the IMO Casualty Investigation Code, in addition to the inquiry. Kaieteur editorial: an unredacted preliminary report within 90 days.
- 4

Government, 25 July:

strengthened compliance with existing standard operating procedures and stricter adherence to existing ticketing and passenger-management rules.
- 5

Janette Bulkan:

published questions asking the Maritime Search and Rescue Coordination Centre to release the rescue timeline and the times at which the Mayday was relayed.
- 6

GHRA:

a parliamentary commission, equal government and opposition membership, judicially qualified chair, duty of candour, state-funded counsel for families. TIGI, Rescue Guyana: an IMO-led investigation.

7. Where the parties stand on the inquiry, as of 26 July 2026

The Government

President Ali announced on 25 July that he would name a five-member Commission of Inquiry on 26 July, describing it as independent and international and comprising “distinguished local and international experts,” with a scope covering loading, boarding, seaworthiness, maintenance history, crew competence, lifesaving arrangements, weather and the search-and-rescue response. At compilation no commissioners, chair, secretary, terms of reference, reporting deadline or statutory basis had been published.

The parliamentary opposition

APNU states the National Assembly should set the terms of reference and include IMO representatives, and has tabled a motion to empower a commission to summon witnesses and compel documents. WIN seeks the recusal of Ministers Edghill and Indar, livestreamed hearings and publication of the full report. The AFC proposes the Commission of Inquiry Act, Cap. 19:03. Jointly, five parties state a Commission of Inquiry is not a substitute for a marine casualty investigation.

Civil society

The GHRA rejects executive appointment and proposes a parliamentary commission with equal government and opposition membership, a judicially qualified chair preferably from elsewhere in the Caribbean, a statutory duty of candour and state-funded counsel for bereaved families. TIGI and Rescue Guyana call for an IMO-led investigation. The APA calls for Minister Edghill’s removal. The National Tshaos Council urges a “comprehensive, transparent, independent review.”

233 1970 — MV Christena. Reported dead, on a vessel certified for 155.

20 2023 — Mahdia fire. Children in state care, mostly Indigenous girls. Families remain in the High Court.

~103 2026 — MV Barima. Implied by subtraction; no official toll published.

Guyanese commentators cited the first two as precedent in July 2026 coverage. The Mahdia figure is given as reported.

Sources. Compiled 26 July 2026 from a 152-source full-text archive and checked against it. Guyanese press: Kaieteur News, Demerara Waves, News Room Guyana, News Source Guyana, Guyana Times, INews Guyana, HGPTV, Democracy Guyana. Official: Department of Public Information (17 disaster-period releases), MARAD and ministerial statements, CARICOM, UNDP Guyana. International: Associated Press, Al Jazeera, Jamaica Observer, Jamaica Gleaner, Caribbean National Weekly, News Americas Now, Barbados Today, CBC Barbados, UPI. Vessel provenance: the Paxman History Pages engine register, a 1930s builder’s document, with the sister ship’s date corroborated by Kaieteur News.

Known limits of this record. Guyana Chronicle, the state newspaper, is absent entirely — a JavaScript wall defeated every retrieval, costing about ten known articles. The MV Christena figures come from a flagged partial capture and need re-verification. The 23:01 Mayday is contradicted by the Prime Minister’s “no such record.” Two survivors named Moonsammy — Elena and Helena — may be different people. Searched for and not found in the corpus: any published capacity certificate, gazetted terms of reference, Auditor General finding on the ferry department, trade union statement, or IMO statement. Stabroek News, publishing for about forty years, ceased print four months before the sinking.